2

His hand reached out blindly for a towel as the errant spray slowed to a dribble. Hurriedly, he dried his face off first. He'd been holding his breath the whole shower–the water on Nar Shaddaa was terrible. It, too, reeked like the rest of this place. And who knew what was in it.

Having quickly toweled off, he stepped out. The water continued to trickle as the facility, its parts corroded and obdurate, creaked back into its standard position. He eyed the shower, grumbling to himself that the landlord had ignored his multiple reminders to fix the faucet before it fully broke. At least water came standard in his rent.

He checked his reflection in the mirror and ran his hands over his face. For a fleeting moment, he considered not bothering with his stubble. Most of his ilk didn't, some out of laziness, others out of either vanity or insecurity, and more still for the benefit of a quick disguise. But massaging his cheeks and catching his fingertips on the raspy growth irritated him, and mechanically, his hand reached for the shaver.

He came out of the refresher dressed and did a quick sweep of the tiny, sparse apartment. The door to the bedroom remained closed, meaning Chewie had not gotten up for the day. A flicker of frustration caught him in the jaw. He'd been hoping that his morning shower would wake the Wook up, and that Chewie might head out for…*whatever*, though that was mostly wishful thinking. The two of them got very little space from each other, and never without checking in first. Some of that, Han accepted, was circumstantial: in almost a year of searching, Chewie had no luck finding any recreation that catered to him. No bars played his music, no restaurants carried his cuisine, no gym facility simulated the climbing of his native environment. Additionally, what universal entertainment he might enjoy was encumbered by the lacking accommodations appropriate to

his large size and a pervasive language barrier–few droids carried programming for Shyriiwook and fewer people still bothered to learn it. What Chewie did do, however, was bumble around at the Spacebarn, picking through the vast warehouse attached to the garage for what spare parts and unique items he could find. Shug sometimes put him to work, too, glad for the Wookiee's strength and knowledge. Of course, the mechanic paid him, and usually offered first dibs on any good parts he found as further compensation. Shug was good like that.

Resigned that they'd be underfoot again to each other for the day, Han crossed to the futon in the living space, fluffing up the pillow and resuming his sprawl across the cushions. Unsatisfied, he reached out for the folded blanket across the back of the couch and tucked it behind his head. His shoulders ached to be back in the same position, and he resolved that–somehow–he'd win the coin toss tonight to get the ample bed in the single bedroom. Reaching behind him, his fingers crept for his comm link, though not without first finding the grip of his pistol. A couple centimeters more, and his fingertips met the cold of the round metal. Snatching it, he turned the comm on its side and opened up the display, mindlessly clearing the notifications for the missed calls and messages from Mako and instead navigating quickly to access the local HoloNet. Landing on the entry to the Hutts' job board, he entered his credentials, then sucked in a breath while it loaded.

After a lag, a list of available runs manifested in faint white text in the gray static of the hologram. His attention skimmed for a particular listing, a scrambling, anxious search coupled with the unspoken wish that it be gone. He scanned and scrolled, scanned and scrolled. The longer it took, the more he felt sure that he was in the clear. Then, he saw it–read it once, unbelieving, then twice to be sure.

CORELLIA.

Bela Vistal, to be specific, running a hefty array of illicit substances, including some secondhand glitterstim.

Han sank further into the couch. It was still on the board, he

acknowledged wearily. He'd seen it last night, and he'd hoped someone had already taken it. As he read it for a third time, he checked the pay, then let out a ragged breath. They'd been offering two bands yesterday. Now it was up to two-four.

There was no debate for him–the answer was no. They could up the pay to three thousand, and the answer would *still* be no. He wasn't going anywhere near the Core, and he certainly wasn't going *there*. He only dreaded getting a call from Deino. She did that sometimes when no one would take a job off the board–call and try to pressure people and bargain with them. As a Corellian, he'd be at the top of the list to contact–all of the dealers around here preferred to send natives. For once, he hoped he was too low on the pecking order to be considered.

He huffed, trying to shake off his angst. It wouldn't matter if he could pick up something else. If he was already beholden to another job, they couldn't ask. He scrolled back up to the top of the list to view his options:

HOLLASTIN, for some "tariff-free" Alderaani wine. He rolled his eyes–not enough pay for the bother.

ORD VAXAL, running a sizable shipment of glitteryll. *Too close to the Imps and the Besadii*, he griped. Pass.

RINGNELDIA II, smuggling in the latest batch of freshly-prohibited navicomputers. The pay was quite good–almost two thousand–but as he read more into the journey and the timeline expected, mapping out his course, he halted as his imaginary trajectory came to the junction at Sleheyron. Both Pabols that stretched in either direction had been choked with brigands the last few months. The advice he'd overheard at the Spacebarn was to circumvent the Rimward space lane by cutting up and taking the Kessel Run.

His mouth twisted at the realization. At the reminder. Not everyone played around the Kessel Run–even the nastiest pirates and most of the Imps stayed away, hovering instead at either end for their quarry. Few aimed for it, but, as some things separate the wheat from

the chaff, for pilots–smugglers, specifically–completing The Run was the means by which others knew to dip their chin to you in acknowledgement and watch their tongue in conversation. Little else counted for as much of a marker of skill than confirmation that you'd successfully run it *at all*, let alone more than once.

He'd flown it once with Rho, a request he'd had to beg the Old Man to concede to. He'd just wanted to see, to say he'd been on it, even if only in the copilot's seat. He kept to himself his limited prior experience with it, about flying for the Besadii and hearing the other smugglers brag. About how much he'd read about it as a youth, least what he could get his hands on, and had even tried his hand at a sim. Nineteen year old him, even with excellent reflexives, sharp eyes, and an intuitive gut, had proven no match.

To come back to Hutt Space older, more experienced, and with a guide like Rho, surely, he was ready. He believed himself prepared–had read over and over again about its composition, about each pilot's particular tricks or techniques, and he'd eavesdropped on the drunken arguments that broke out sometimes at The Blue Light about which way through was the fastest. Fastest, he'd learned, meant *safest*, and Rho had reiterated that to him: the only way to do the Run was by the seat of your pants. And damn, had Rho flown that way–even though they'd already done about five months worth of jobs together at that point, Han had never seen Rho not only so strained, but so *locked in*, channeling an alertness and speed the Old Man had never had to tap into before. They'd finished the Run successfully and exhausted, though not without a few pings on the hull of Rho's *Lwyll*.

Han had come off that trip thrilled, eager to finally secure his own vessel so he could claim ascendancy with his own crew on his own ship. Reality caught up with him quickly. Taking the 'Suub–as she was then and as she still was–into The Run would be a death sentence.

He stared again at the listing for RII, this time aware of the sharp pressure at his brow. He hadn't given up, not entirely. He made progress on getting his ship together, just…not as much as he'd like. But eventually. Soon, even. He wanted to know he could do it. He

wanted everyone else to know it, too.

[*What are you going to do today*?]

Han's eyes darted up from his comm display to find Chewie hovering in the threshold to the living room. "What do you mean?" he answered, incredulous, gesturing brashly at the job board.

[*You don't think Shug is right*?] the Wook started softly. [*That we should take a breather*?]

"We don't have time for that," Han exhaled with irritation, trying to turn back to his display.

[*But the ship–*]

"The ship will be fine," Han insisted. "She's good. And what she needs, we can't do until I have more money in my hand."

The Wookiee chewed on that. [*Okay*] he tried again [*granted you **don't** find work, what are you going to do today*?]

Anger bloomed in Han's chest. Every time…they had this conversation *every time*. He resented being babysat, and more so that he was expected to treat it as normal. He could yell, certainly, or try to chase Chewie off, but he'd already tried that and learned swiftly that it made no difference. The Wookiee would hover at his heels. Those were the conditions of the life debt.

He grimaced as he shrugged. "I might fiddle in the sims today. Kinda would like to keep practicing that dummy dump." He fleetingly glanced up at Chewie. "Why, what are you doing?"

[*I want to double check the patch correction we made yesterday. Make sure it held. After that, I'm sure Shug can find something for me to do*.]

"Well, good," Han snipped, sarcastic. "It'll give you some spending money. I can't afford to keep feeding you all by myself."

Chewie stared at him silently, clearly deciding how to respond. [*Let me know if anything changes*] he eventually said flatly, then made for the door.

"Yeah, I will," Han replied, turning his attention to the corner of the room. Distantly, he heard the door click closed at Chewie's leaving. He lay there for a few moments more, somehow both restless

and listless, then stood up in one dynamic movement. He'd eat something–that would distract him–and then he could check the board again. Maybe in an hour's time, a decent opportunity would crop up.

Once in the dinky kitchenette, his hand reached for the cupboard handle, swinging it up impatiently. Bare. He checked the cooler to find it in the same condition. Scowling, he inspected a high cabinet and felt a wash of relief to see a package of stimm tea. As his hand grabbed the tea, though, it was lighter than he expected. He shook it, frowning, then checked the inside. Empty. Only then did he remember that he'd used the last of the grounds their last time planetside. He'd made a mental note to replace it, but…

Fine, he grumbled, he'd head out and just get breakfast. Not like he was going to spend the day cooped up in the cramped apartment anyway. He threw boots on and strapped himself up, then locked the apartment and exited his building, a teetering residential tower like many in the Corellian Sector, at Level 13. It was still fairly early in the day, and the denizens of this corner of the moon were slow to wake. Nar Shaddaa in general operated like a nocturnal creature, but the Corellian Sector in particular–home to many of the pilots that did the Hutts' grunt work–usually stayed quiet until the afternoon rain passed.

He cut across a metal skyway that connected to another tower and jogged down an open stairwell until he hit Level 10. Levels 10 down to 7 contained the bulk of the businesses and store fronts, and he moved at a swift pace, as sensitive to the knot in his stomach as he was aware it made him less of a target for accosting. Still, as he turned a corner, he bumped into a little kid–a girl, likely not even double digits–who raised her hands up in reaching, pleading grasps.

"Mister, can you help me, I–"

Han deftly dipped away, then scooted past the kid, turning eyes up the street. There was *always* a kid on the street, each with their different sob story, perfectly performed to sucker unwitting newcomers into donating a few credits, either consciously or not.

Reflexively, he checked his pockets, making sure the kid had swiped nothing while bumping into him. That was always a good trick, when little else worked. Once upon a time, he'd even used it.

He finally came to the revolving doors of an unassuming little diner and pushed his way through. Only a handful of patrons sat scattered across the dining room; he paused and scoped their faces but recognized no one. Behind the counter, though, stood a familiar figure, her graying blond hair swept into an updo as always. She had her back to him as she haggled with the droid on the line, and Han smirked as he took a seat at the counter.

"Stimm tea, when you get a chance," he called out during a lull in her conversation, and she spun at the sound of his voice.

"Fly boy," she crooned, smiling at her tease before her hand went to the kettle at her side. She poured a cup and placed it before him. "Haven't seen you in a minute."

"I've been occupied," he answered, then took a sip. The tea was hot and thick and bitter–terribly overbrewed. He winced against the acerbic flavor, but at least appreciated he could even get stimm tea on demand here.

"You want your usual?" she asked, her attention seemingly busied elsewhere, but the slight perk in her eyebrows meant she was listening.

"Yeah, but just two eggs, not three," he clarified while he shook some salt into the mug. He studied the back counter as he took another sip. He had never really been one for sweets, but he made an exception for whatever it was she made here. "Got any of those little…?" He folded his fingers to mimic the shape of the pastry.

"*Ghlahnas*," she corrected as she slid a few on a plate towards him. Today, they had some kind of orange jam, but she'd not made a bad one yet. "One of these days, you'll remember."

He grinned at her playfully, then hungrily ate one. "Rho around?" he managed with a full mouth.

She swiveled away from him, though he still caught the grimace on her face. "Hasn't been in yet this morning," she answered

curtly. “Are you getting anything else?”

When he shook his head, she held out her hand and announced his total. Swiftly recalling what credits he had on him, Han fished a coin out of his pocket and handed it to her.

Satisfied, Lwyll started to turn away, but then her eye caught what sat in her palm and she halted, stretching her open hand out to him. “That doesn’t have any use to me here.”

He faltered, unsure of what she meant, then followed her gaze down to the coin. An Imperial unit. “Right,” he answered, then dug in a different pocket and pulled out a smaller, golden coin. “Still getting used to the peggat.”

Seamlessly, she took the coin and fished in her apron to make his change. Dropping the coins on the counter, she left to take some plates fresh off the line. Han scooped the coins into his palm, turning them in the light, checking that the size and color of each matched his expectations.

“You think I’d cheat you?” he heard her squawk, and Han’s gaze darted up to see Lwyll glaring at him, all incredulous with an armful of breakfast platters.

He smiled quickly, eager to charm. “Can never be too careful,” he offered, to which she playfully scoffed as she left to unburden herself.

He’d finished his *ghlahnas* by the time she returned, and she silently cleared his plate then wiped down the counter. Then, at prompting from behind her, she pivoted in smooth fashion to collect and then present the hot plate of marlello eggs swimming in a chunky green sauce of blended and spiced celonslay to him. She hovered as she watched Han pull apart the accompanying flatbread, then raised eyebrows at him as he ate. “And?”

He nodded, then hurried down a swallow. “Closer. A lot closer. Maybe a little more of the vinegar.”

Her eyes creased in a smirk. “Maybe you should just come work the line,” she teased, then checked his mug and filled his cup again without asking.

"Maybe I open up a place next door and put Veno out of business."

"You do what you want with Veno," she tittered, then raised a sardonic eyebrow. "He doesn't pay me enough to stay here." At that, her focus followed her hand as she habitually wiped down the counter, but a refraction of sunlight from the revolving door made her look up. She paused, shifting her weight to one hip while she stifled a laugh. "Well, here comes a mess."

"Lwyll, I know you keep liquor back there," growled a voice with an extra layer of grit that indicated a particularly rough night. "Charge me as much as you want, just gimme the damn shot."

Han spun to hear the newcomer, extending a hand. "I'll take it they rummaged your pockets empty," he jibed as he examined his friend up and down, registering the exhaustion in his face.

Mako Spince was only a decade older than him, but silver had already streaked through his long dark locks and his sharp blue-white eyes creased heavily when he laughed, as he did now. "You should have come with me last night," the smuggler said as he shook. "Brought the house down at Jacinda's."

Han waved him off. Having some half-interested, dope-sick floozy drool over him while he spent his money getting the both of them drunk did nothing for him. "Not my scene," he reminded Mako before turning back to his breakfast.

As requested, Lywll had gone and come back with a bottle in her hand, and she generously poured into a mug a clear liquid that reeked of flux. Mako brought it to his lips as soon as she set it down, then leaned into the bartop wincing as he recovered from downing the swill. Still grimacing, he gestured for her to give him another.

"Eat this first, then we can talk about a second one," she bade, and placed before him a small plate with gummy, white fruit slices.

"*Isfa*?!" Mako questioned with disgust as he stepped back from the counter. "I think I'd rather you just hit me over the head with the bottle."

"Eat it," Lwyll barked. "It'll fix your hangover."

Cringing, Mako lifted a slice to his face, inspecting it closer. The Nar Shaddese ate the fruit fanatically, in the mornings usually turning it into a smoothie, and the list of its alleged health benefits could stretch as far as Nal Hutta and back. The tree it grew on was pretty enough, with spindly, twirling purple leaves with green stripes down the middle, but the oblong fruit stunk like the inside of a boot. Han had tried it once, just to see…and immediately reminded himself to pick up stimm tea in bulk whenever he came across it off-world.

Somehow, Mako forced himself through one slice, then a second, then…either the *isfa* or whatever liquor he'd shot sank into him, and he settled down into the bar stool beside Han, chewing idly. He watched Han continue to eat his own breakfast, then squinted. "Squared away?" he observed, then let go of a snarky laugh. "They really did break you in, didn't they?"

Han snorted, then turned to Mako with a wry grin. "You're just mad I'm too pretty to hide behind a beard."

At mention of it, Mako's hands combed down over his own facial hair, a full beard that on a good day he kept reasonably clean, but today bore witness to his overnight escapades. "Surprised you're still here," Mako started again as he gnashed through another sloppy stalk of fruit.

Han heard him, but busied himself with pushing around half an egg on his plate first. "Waiting for something good," he answered just before stuffing his face.

"You know," Mako continued, barely talking over his chewing, "you could stop scrounging around for loose change if you would just suck it up and take these bigger jobs."

Han paused and gawked, digging his tongue into food stuck in his cheek. "Like Utapau?"

Mako rolled his eyes as he shifted himself around on the stool, pushing the now empty plate away from him. "I thought I heard that Drea was going to work something out with them, at least for us."

"Have to ask Rho next time you see him," Han shrugged.

At that, Mako chortled. "Still runnin' to Rho about every

damn thing. You're such a greenhorn."

"You've only got two more years on me out here," Han countered without pause, "and I was a better pilot than you from the start. Still am."

"Not good enough to go towards Utapau," Mako taunted.

Han shook his head, resolute. "I *don't* go that way."

"Well, I guess that means I'm braver than you," the older man touted.

Han guffawed. "It means you're more reckless."

"Reckless and rich."

This made Han snap. "And how much are you blowing on however many crates of equipment it'll cost you to get her back into shape?! Plus how long you'll be stuck down here." He shook his head. "It doesn't make sense."

Even to a smuggler, losing gracefully in a verbal match was expected. At least, that is, if he was sober. Mako was not. He leaned hard into the bar top, staring intently, studying Han as his expression grew increasingly devilish. "You don't want that Corellia job?" he finally asked, proud of his goad.

Han froze in his seat, then tightly turned to stare at Mako, aware of the tension in his brow and jaw. They'd had too much time together for Mako to not know where the line was.

Rather than back down, however, Mako seemed giddy that his comment had landed. "What's the matter?" he baited again. "Worried that dusty con artist will collar you?"

Han's neck blushed with heat at the dig. It was low, even for Mako–apparently, he was still drunker than he realized. The urge to punch the smarmy smirk off his friend's face–drunk or not–surfaced, but he had better ammunition than that. "Why don't you take it?" Han answered smoothly, though perhaps still unable to completely mask his vitriol. "Have a little family reunion with your old man."

Mako's countenance changed. He sat up, his expression caught somewhere between unease and disgust. "I ain't got no business on Corellia," he insisted through gritted teeth.

"Me, either," Han answered coolly. He waited a beat, then turned back to his near-empty plate.

The two then sat in silence for a minute or so, Han absorbed in enjoying the last of his meal while Mako remained still, brooding. When Lwyll returned, her eager eyes checking over the two men for what she could provide, Mako evaded her gaze, then slipped off towards the 'fresher with a grumble.

"What's stuck in his craw?" Lwyll asked, struck at the abrupt change, but Han only shrugged and feigned ignorance. "You smugglers are all the same," she lamented, clearing his plate.

He wouldn't argue with her, and instead reclined in his seat to nurse the last of his stimm. After only a couple sips, he toyed with the idea of checking the board again. Maybe something was different. Maybe *that job* was finally gone. But when he checked his watch and saw that it hadn't yet been an hour, he reasoned he'd not tempt fate. Apprehension tingled at his spine; he was not good at waiting.

"You want another cup? I'll give it to you free."

Han's head snapped up to see Lwyll considering him. He flashed her a grin, waving his hand over the mug. "I'm all set. Thanks."

She looked like was going to say more when movement at the doorway caught her attention again. Her face fell. "Well, you got your wish," Lywll said flatly, then tsked as she turned her attention to another customer down the bar top.

Han followed her line of sight to watch an older man–medium height with a rounded gut that testified to his age and lifestyle–come through the doors with three other people. As soon as the man entered, the various patrons in the dining room all raised a hand in recognition. That had been Han's first lesson upon coming to the Smuggler's Moon: you always acknowledge the other pilots already present, and particularly in Veno's Vit Spot. Mean mugging carried little currency here. The enthusiasm for this visitor, however, wasn't rooted in custom but rather candor, and the man stepped forward to say hi to a few people and shake hands. Han watched from the bar,

unsure if he'd been noticed and not especially wanting undue attention, but Rho caught sight of him and lit up with a smile.

"Han!" he boomed, strolling over.

At the prompting, the younger man rose, meeting Rho halfway to accept his extended, meaty hand in greeting. The older pilot patted him on the arm, warm and friendly as always, then his gaze went over Han's shoulder to the figure still busying herself behind the counter.

"Hello, Beautiful," the Old Man crooned.

"Rho, I don't wanna hear it," Lywll chided while she hurriedly organized the back counter. "I'm here to work; I'm not here to entertain you." She spun, scowling at him. "When are you gonna listen to my no?"

"When you stop saying yes to my comm calls," he waxed. "You keep answering, I'll keep calling and coming to see you. You're my sweetheart."

She rolled her eyes. "I'm not answering anymore."

"You always say that," he said after a guffaw. "Four *isfa* slurries to the table in the corner?"

Though she said nothing, the flicker in her eyes meant she'd heard, and she stepped off to complete the order.

Han, meanwhile, had done what he could to hide his bewilderment. This back-and-forth happened every time he saw them together, and Rho's dogged insistence on chasing after Lwyll never made sense to him. Rho had been asking her for forever to marry him. Lwyll had in turn been putting him off, citing the danger of his career choice, reaffirming she would be no smuggler's widow. And yet, his efforts only intensified each year that went by, and though she continued to see him–likely falling for how thoroughly he adored her–her response had not changed: only if he officially retired.

Rho must have missed the cringe on Han's face, as he turned to the Corellian, still beaming. "Haven't seen you in a while–you look good! How you holdin' up?"

"I'm keepin' busy."

"You finally get that ship to bend to your will?" the older man

asked with raised brows. "I'm telling you, Han, I wish you'd brought me with you. Ploy ain't a bunko, but he *is* a salesman."

"She's…" The truth hung at the back of his tongue. "Great," he forced out, smiling to cover up the lie. "She's doin' real great. And it seems you're busy, too."

"No shortage of people in line to learn the ropes," Rho laughed. "You newbies keep me young!"

Han gestured inquisitively at the other three people who Rho had walked in with. Though they had started to get comfortable at a booth in the corner, they were throwing glances in the Old Man's direction. "Trainees?" he asked.

"Them? Ha, those clowns are too old to be trainees." The Old Man nudged Han. "Come, sit!"

Instantly, Han assessed Rho's associates. As usual, he recognized none of the faces. It seemed Rho knew damn near everybody on Nar Shaddaa, and Han had lost count of the people he'd been introduced to during run-ins such as these.

"I dunno, I should prob–"

"Come *on*, Han, don't be shy!" Rho coaxed, demanding and yet warm. "You're gonna make it here, you're gonna have to learn a little how to socialize."

With Rho's hand at his back, Han walked ahead towards the booth, trying to suss again if he recognized anyone. He didn't. There were three: a Duros in the middle, a Togruta with impressively long montrals flanked on one side and a third, probably an Onderonian, on the other. As Rho got settled into a chair pulled up beside the booth– the Old Man's gut wouldn't allow him a comfortable seat any other way–Han shook hands in greeting. He made no effort to remember the names they shared.

"–and then I had another walk up, try to lie to me about where she'd come from," the Togruta continued, ignoring the newcomers. "I could smell it on her."

"Core?" questioned the Duros.

"*Blue*," the Togruta hissed. "They think they can ditch the

patch, change the story. It's bullshit."

The other members of the table wordlessly exchanged glances. Han, meanwhile, busied himself with readjusting in his seat, turning his head to sweep the diner again just in time to see Mako return. They met eyes; the older Corellian audited in whose company Han now sat, then only to looked long at them before turning away. There'd be no traipsing over; Mako was Core, though he'd done a good job hiding *how* connected he truly was–or, at least, had been. He'd been far from silent about his expeditious expulsion from the Academy–what *should* have been a prison sentence, Han knew–which had helped smooth over the rough edges of his history, but any mention of that place had carried with it a cost. No one around here forgot or forgave.

"You all heard about Utapau?" the Togruta spit out like it was a bad taste in his mouth.

The question seemed to distress Rho. "Come on, we can't even start breakfast first?"

"It's a mess," the Togruta continued. "Whole damn thing."

"It's good for business," the Duros countered.

"Not necessarily," Rho cut in, a weariness to his answer. "Pros and cons to all of it."

"I don't see the pros," answered the Onderonian. "Skipping around the Republic was one thing. Even officials on Utapau were fine to work around. But the Imps? It's somethin' else."

"It's not just that, either," the Togruta added. "I was on Utapau…I dunno, six months ago? No sign that the Imperials were gonna push in like that. And then, like overnight–*woosh*–they swarmed."

"And it's good for *business*!" the Duros argued again.

The Togruta fumed. "Good for whose business, and for how long? Who you shipping to, and where from? Shit, man, they ate up the Core in short order, and now they're making their way along the spacelanes. *Now* they got a new blockade at Brentaal IV."

"They *what*?!" came a chorus of voices.

The Torgruta leaned into his indignation. “Blue Shirts set up a blockade right at Brentaal IV where the Commenor meets the Hydian. Some Senate bullshit. Anyway, three freighters gone of Aila’s. Just gone. Not on records or nothing. No word or ransom or salvage. Like they disappeared.”

“*Disappeared?*” questioned Rho, skeptical. “Disappeared according to who?”

“According to Aila,” was the answer, delivered almost smugly. “Said she’s sent them out and never heard back. No reason for them to split–they’d left in good spirits.”

At that, all of them pulled back slightly, searching each other's faces and then inspecting their own reactions. Han especially withdrew. He was familiar with the area; it had been more than a few years, but he’d been all around there–Ixtlar, Corulag, Esseles. Even actually stepped foot on Chandrila once. It didn’t surprise him that the Imps were squatting over Brentaal–that was a busy little intersection. Holding that area meant controlling one of the main lanes into the Core; the Perlimian was there, too, which led right onto Coruscant.

But a ship disappearing? Strange. It sounded like the work of pirates, not the Imps–they usually weren’t shy about announcing they’d impounded something or blew it to bits. He couldn’t help but speculate…maybe it was neither. Maybe the crew was just trying to skirt around the Imperials and jumped wrong. It was possible to get stuck in hyperspace; it was the risk they all took tinkering with hyperdrives to make them faster and playing around in coordinates that weren’t secure.

“It makes me nervous,” the Togruta continued. “This work’s risky, and getting riskier. How long til the Imps start eating up all the places we *do* business? How long until they come here?”

“They’re not comin’ here,” Rho answered, trying to reassure.

The Togruta’s montrals twitched. “They might. Certainly dropped a lot of language last couple years about tightening up on port authority, about raising the bar for clearance checks.”

"They have their damn hands full," Rho answered again. "No point to comin' here. They won't poke at the Hutts, much as they don't like each other. That's talk to *make* us nervous, to make us fold. Make stupid mistakes. Now, can we drop it for a bit? You guys talkin' like this is gonna get my stomach acid up, and I don't even have anything on my gut." Rho sat up straight then, a glint in his eye as he smiled over Han's shoulder. "My love, you have perfect timing!"

Lwyll said nothing as she distributed the *isfa* slurries to each person, though Han caught a tinge of warmth at the corner of her eyes. She rested a hand on Han's shoulder. "You wanna take me up now on that extra cup of stimm?"

"Yeah, sure," Han answered.

"Must be a newbie if he hasn't picked up the *isfa* habit," the Duros snickered. He sucked a little on his pale green slushie first before adding, "How long you been flyin' with the Old Man?"

Han flustered. "Oh, I don't fly wit–"

"Han's his own captain," Rho interjected. "Didn't fly with me long. Solo here had a solid head on his shoulders and quite the feel for the yoke. Wasn't too much left for me to teach."

Han sheepishly folded his lips over at Rho's answer. As was usual of the older man, he was being generous. Han had indeed come with extensive flying experience and knew a thing or two about illegal markets, but Rho had shown him the ropes of the business, sharing his sweeping and seasoned wisdom, as he'd done to dozens upon dozens of pilots new to the trade.

"What'cha piloting?" asked the Duros.

Han's eyes darted up first before flickering over at Rho, who was giving his full attention to fiddling with an uncrushed lump of *isfa* in his smoothie. "Uh, a *Starmite*. Older model, about thirty."

"Outfitted?" questioned the Onderonian.

Han sucked in a big breath again. "Well, sort of. Got some extra plating on her and she came with a couple guns, but–"

"You're the one!" the Togruta interrupted, brightening with recognition. "You're the one with that little red tin can!" He chortled. "I heard about that! Crazy that you're flyin' that old thing."

"Kind of impressive, in a way," the Onderonian tried.

"It's a fine ship," Rho countered, and as he said it, the others cooled. "Don't need the biggest and baddest to do the job. Just need the right tool."

Though Han could feel the heat at his neck–and Rho's comment did little to assuage *him*–he did everything he could to hide his grimace. Stay calm…some kind of graceful.

"Where'd you learn to pilot?" questioned the Onderonian.

Han's eyebrows raised in surprise at the question. "Uh, did a lot of swoop racing when I was younger. There's a learning curve to flying the big ships, but not too much of one." He then grinned, hoping that none would push any further and pull apart his partial truth.

"Swoop racing?" interjected the Togruta. "I used to follow–should I recognize you?"

Han stalled. By all accounts, the answer should have been yes. Han should have been to report–honestly!–that he'd won dozens of tournaments, including some big prizes. He'd even taken a couple holostills with a few notable professional swoop racers in the later part of his career. But instead of offering the yes, Han deflated. All those accolades had not been done in *his* name; Shrike had forbidden it. He'd flown as someone else, and that person didn't exist anymore.

Lwyll indeed had great timing, as she arrived again, placing the mug full of steaming, burnt stimm in front of him. That gave Han enough distraction to hide his grimace. "Only raced in the junior leagues. Not much to share."

"You fly for the Hutts now?" asked the Onderonian.

Masking his relief at the new topic, Han gave a tight nod. "Yeah. Mostly take work around the Outer Rim. Try to avoid the Blue Shirts, you know. Not really interested in risking it rotting away in Narkina Five." A joke, sort of, but he grinned big to sell it.

"The slugs are lucky this old bastard keeps feeding them talent," the Togruta cut in. "They manage to sink their grubby hands into the new ones, and then you all like the money too much to leave." He tittered, something world-weary about him. "Eventually, you'll get tired. You'll see reason, if you live long enough. We all do." And as he shot a glance around at his associates, the rest of the table joined him in a knowing chuckle.

Han laughed too, reflexive, then his mouth half-twisted. "What's unreasonable about them?"

That earned a chorus of guffaws, but it was the Onderonian that met Han's gaze to answer. "You're young yet. You'll learn."

Cryptic was Han's least favorite type of response, but even Rho had joined in on the laughter, so Han busied himself with trying to suck down some of the awful stimm. *Buy more the next chance you get*, he reminded himself again as he struggled through the bilge. He then darted his gaze around, aware he wasn't so good at small talk. "Uh…what do you all do?"

"Mostly move droid parts from Mechis III, bound for the Mid Rim," the Duros answered. "The black market for them can have pretty thin margins, but I have a solid supplier."

The Onderonian gestured at himself and the Togruta. "Got an inside on rare ore." He chuckled. "Stupid Imps shortchange the mine operators and then expect them to not take a handout on the side."

"I also do a bunch of small business up and down the Triellus," the Togruta added after a lull. "Nothin' covert, just necessities."

"Yeah, but–" his business partner interjected.

"No, I told you," the Togruta flared, his montrals twitching in agitation, "there ain't nothin' wrong with small and steady. It's good insurance. Who knows what will happen out here."

"When you have a hand for it," his partner cut back in.

"Pilots can be in short supply," the Togruta explained. "Nobody wants to take anything small."

At this, Han's ears perked. He shifted his weight a little,

thinking. "How small?"

The Togruta blinked at Han's question in surprise. "I got a shipment headed out to Junkfort. Just some basic supplies and trinkets. It'll only pay about six hundred, so I can't get any takers."

Han's brain darted through the math. To Junkfort Station and back would only take him a few days, and it was a straightforward trip if he took the Shag Pabol Lane to Teth and then picked up the Triellus. Six hundred would be the lowest he'd been paid since he got here, but if it bought him time away from Nar Shaddaa enough for the Hutts' job board to refresh…

"I'll do it," he blurted out.

"You're *sure*?" Rho asked beside him after a beat, incredulous. "That's not really–"

"Yeah, it's fine," Han said, maybe too fast, eager to play cool. "It'll be nice to do a simple trip, and Junkfort probably needs those supplies." *And anything is better than no work.*

"Well, that'll be great, thanks." The Togruta then reached into a pocket and pulled out his comm. At the prompting, Han did the same, and they touched devices to exchange information. "I'll send you all the info right now. The pickup's in a warehouse north a ways."

"Great." Han smiled as warmly as he could before he started to get up from his seat. "Well, I'll get a move on then–better go so I can come back. Nice meeting you all!"

Relief flooded him as he stepped out onto the street: he had work, and a sufficient alibi if Deino happened to call before he was out of radio distance.

Now to slip back to the 'Suub. He didn't want Chewie to come, he acknowledged as he walked; it was a quick jaunt, no biggie, no real reason to bring him along. They could use some time apart, too, he rationalized. Maybe doing something like this would get the Wookiee to realize he didn't need to be so obstinate about hovering. And, he admitted–though a smidge guiltily–going alone would mean not having to divvy up the pay.

Han entered the Spacebarn as stealthily as he could, eyeing

across the hangar for Chewie's unmissable stature. Since the central corridor seemed clear, Han hurried as much as he could, cognizant of movement in and out of each bay, eager to duck into a threshold if need be. He slipped past Bays 20 through 11, just barely dodging out of view before an acquaintance picked his head up from his welding, then hugged the wall outside Bay 10. Craning his ear, he couldn't hear any noise that would suggest Chewie was still working on the hull, if he'd even begun the job. Granted, he was still a few bays away, so he'd need to be cautious, but it was looking good that he could–

"Hey, Captain Solo, need help?"

Han froze in place and swore under his breath, though he managed to fix his face before he spun to meet the voice. As he turned, he seized with the same shock–disquiet?–that always gripped him each time he saw the boy, whose dark eyes, shaggy hair, and tawny complexion so closely resembled his own at that age.

"Hey." He paused, struggling to remember the kid's name. "Jarik–no, I don't need any help."

"You're headed out?" the kid questioned brightly. "Want me to fetch Chewie for you?"

So he's not *in the bay*, Han surmised. "Uh, where is he?"

"Shug pulled him to help with some scrap job. They're up in Bay Four."

That was perfect. "No," he answered, trying to hide his grin. "I'm just, uh…going for a spin in the obstacle course."

"Gotcha," the kid replied, his face bright. He started to turn back to wherever he'd come from, but then paused. "Uh, Captain Solo? Do you think maybe someday I could come with?"

Han had also already started to leave, but stopped. "Come *with*? Come with *where*?"

Jarik's gaze darted around. "You know…to the obstacle course. Or…on a run?"

He couldn't hold it in. "*On a run?!* What the fuck for?"

"I could do whatever'd be helpful! Be an extra set of eyes, shoot some people." The kid aimed at the distance with his fingers,

pretending to fire, then dropped his hands with a self-satisfied grin.

Han scoffed, waving him off. "It ain't fun and games up there, Kid. It's dangerous. Now scram." Eager to not waste his window, Han darted forward, marching his way into his bay and heading straight for the keypad. His fingers entered his access data robotically, and the gangplank started its descent. He was up into the ship before it had even finished and hurried himself into the cockpit. All he needed was to get out quick and cleanly, and his hands flew around his instrument panel, muscle memory guiding him to all of the controls he'd lately yielded to Chewie.

As he barreled out of the access chute and went careening across the Industrial Sector, he finally uploaded the directions from the Togruta. As promised, the warehouse sat about fifty kilometers north of Kha'art Hadash, so it was a speedy journey. As he flew, Han's eyes mindlessly scanned the land below him. Nar Shaddaa's development stretched to the horizon and beyond. Every square meter of this place, all the way around the moon, it was all the same: squalid and gray.

Pick up went smoothly enough. The warehouse manager had everything on a dolly ready to go. The goods loaded and secured, he was back in his captain's chair in less than fifteen minutes, then in a blink had climbed altitude and broken atmosphere. The entrance to the hyperspace lane widened as he approached, and he plugged in the coordinates to Teth. As he pulled on the throttle, and space warped around him, the tension in his chest loosened. Freedom.

Upon his arrival at Junkfort Station–a dingy little depot that attracted ships in need of repair and goods too hot to take elsewhere–Han's contact seemed surprised but pleased nonetheless to see him, perhaps even relieved. Drop off likewise went smoothly, enough for Han to question while he departed whether he was an idiot for taking tougher or riskier jobs. Perhaps things didn't need to be so difficult?

In fact, he was quite satisfied with himself as he disengaged from hyperspace again at Teth, one more jump from returning to Nar Shaddaa. Transitioning, Han grabbed the yoke, coaching himself

aloud as he peered far into the Black, on the other side of the planet, where the next hyperspace terminal waited. His hand pulled at the controls to straighten the *Starmite* out, but as he did so, she only corrected in one axis. He frowned, then tried again. Still, the ship could dip and lift her nose, but not move port to starboard.

Luckily, panic was unnecessary. The lateral controls had done this a handful of times before. If he shut the ship down and waited a few minutes, then booted her back up, she'd respond. This was just something else to fiddle with when he got back, a nuisance more than an emergency.

With what controls he had, he guided the 'Suub well out of the spacelane, then smoothly moved through his shutdown procedure. With the last flick of a switch, the lights cut out in the cockpit. Now, to sit. Patience wasn't one of his virtues, but a few moments of silence didn't sound so bad. He sucked in a big breath, then let it out slowly, letting his hands fall casually between his knees.

The 'Suub floated aimlessly, Teth drifting slightly out of her sights. Ahead of the little *Starmite*, more ships dropped out of hyperspace, then kicked on their sublight engines and started off to the planet ahead. Han watched them closely, identifying vessels as they passed through his view window. There was a smattering of small ships, nothing large enough to see clearly from his waning perspective, but then a pod of corvettes manifested, five he counted, *Marauder-class*, manufactured by… He squinted, trying to remember. Sienar Technologies–that was it, out of the Tion System. He leaned forward, studying their immaculate hulls. Space did a number on ships. The ones that flew dealt with the onslaught of particles, physical and energy, that pinged and scraped and gouged the hull every moment that shields needed to drop. The ships that cruised, that held positions for long periods of time out in the dead of space, got ate up by the anaerobic bacteria that clung to ship metal. His 'Suub wore scars of both.

A *Carrack* cruiser dropped, though as he studied her, it appeared she'd been stripped of her guns and retrofitted. *Must be a*

cheap transport vessel, he reasoned, *the kind you find a spot in and squat for a few hours. No amenities, just port to port*. Then, more small ships skittered in: an Alderanni yacht; another little Sorosuub vessel similar to the *Starmite*; and, behind them, a YV-3300 freighter.

At recognition of the vessel, Han couldn't help a small grin. The YV was the newest model series from the Corellian Engineering Corporation, and nobody built like CEC. That cargo ship with a pistol-shaped design was *ugly*, but dammit if she couldn't duck and dodge like a mosgoth, then slap your ass so hard you'd cough out your insides. She probably came with a Class 2 hyperdrive, too, a daring little racer that would make the 'Suub, with her torpid Class 5, look like an Old Republic puddle jumper. CEC built to last, too; that ship would thrive another two hundred years past all these sleeker models, and she'd take to mods like a dream. He could customize her into whatever he wanted. A ship like that would let him take some of the tougher jobs the Desilijic put on the board. Or more. Nobody would catch him. *That* was what he needed.

The YV-3300 zipped around the edge of Teth, returning Han to the present. *Another minute*, he resigned, then he should be good to go. His attention wandered back up to the spacelane, curious what else would pass through the junction point, and he watched a Gymsnor-4 freighter skip its way across the gulf in space.

Salla, he remembered, then smiled a little to himself. Salla flew a G-4, the *Rimrunner*. In fact, he'd think that ship might actually *be* her, except it missed the custom concussion missile launchers she'd installed. This was her territory, though; she'd planethop across the Outer Rim, hitting her favorite depots to haggle for illegal arms and trade munitions. Salla swore no loyalties to any particular government and would sell guns to any group, though she favored swiping materiel shipments from the Imps and then distributing them to the various smuggling groups and cartels in the periphery of Imperial space. They'd bonded over that.

She might be back by the time he returned, he realized, and he sucked in a tight breath of pleasure to think of stopping by her place.

She'd meet him at the door with her full lips all tight and guarded, amber eyes questioning what exactly he wanted. He'd wave the bag of groceries he'd picked up. That was their deal: he cooked, she cleaned up afterwards. Lucky him that the lady could hit the center of a decicred from twenty paces away but couldn't boil water. She'd let him in, her tone continuing to be critical, but he could charm when he wanted, and she'd soften just enough for him to stay the night.

Suddenly eager to return, his focus shifted to rebooting the 'Suub. Yet as he reached for the first of his myriad controls, an alarm sounded through his cockpit. Not a mechanical alarm, not a system failure…a proximity alarm. He leaned over his screen, eager to make sense of what exactly had tripped his sensors, but the display was a blob that didn't register to him. He cursed, unsure whether to waste time trying to solve the mystery or if he should prioritize getting the ship online so he could speed out of the area.

And then the hair on the back of his neck stood up. So too, it rose down his arms–even his leg hairs prickled–as he froze. The radar made sense. He knew that shape. Breathless, he sat up in his captain's chair, then gawked out the view window.

A white, arrowed-headed ship loomed above him, slowly passing into his ken. She was so massive and so close, she couldn't fit in the whole view window, and Han ducked forward to get a better look. He scrutinized her hull, identifying turbolasers and ion cannons, then recognized the succession of hangars on her starboard side. She had space for a complement of seventy-two assorted TIE fighters, enough to carpet-bomb a major metropolis to ashes in less than an hour. Over 1,600 meters long, she could hold almost five thousand officers and easily twice as many stormtroopers. Anxious, he gulped. It had been a while since he'd been this close to an *Imperial*-class Star Destroyer.

Han couldn't take his eyes from that almost-white triangular shape. His first thought, when he finally became capable of having them again, was to question what the hell an ISD was doing in this part of space. He was nowhere near Empire territory–strung between

Hutt Space and Wild Space was about as far as anybody could get from them. Teth had nothing of immediate value for the Imps–or, at least, they were usually pretty good about picking and choosing their targets, and the planet wasn't worth the fight with the Hutts. And a single Star Destroyer, massive and gunned as she was, wasn't enough to terrorize a planet or crush a resistance fleet.

He steeled against the rising panic. There was a reason he had an alarm for Imperial vessels: a month back, he and Chewie had barely dodged a customs check, a new installation at the hyperspace junction around Milagro. He believed it likely they hadn't snagged any of his data–and he'd wiped the ship's info on returning to be sure–but had written in the alarm regardless. It never hurt to be too careful, especially around Blue Shirts. Now, stuck beneath them, he tried to reassure himself that staying put was for the best. As far as the ISD was concerned, his ship likely looked like jetsam. Engines off, she might not even register on their sensors. Just to be sure, without taking his eyes off the looming giant, his hands reached behind him and flicked off his emergency systems. The ship now sat completely dead. Better safe than sorry.

He'd let them pass all the way before he kicked engines back on, he reasoned. Thus, he waited, perfectly still as the Star Destroyer glided on. He had admit–there was a certain elegance to the craft that inspired a stiff reverence, in the same way he held an odd, uncomfortable respect for a krykna.

It dawned on him, then, that he was glad Chewie hadn't come with. For as much he himself disliked them, Chewie's feelings rightfully ran so much deeper. To be human under the Empire meant having to face an increasingly strict if not outright authoritarian rule. Keep your head down, and then maybe once the Empire asserted itself, you could reasonably function within their new paradigm, though you'd be stupid to not keep your mouth shut, too. For non-humans, though…the Empire had little tolerance for their kind. Imperial superiority was *human* superiority, and the Empire had incrementally escalated their anti-alien sentiments and policies since

officially seizing power. Certain types of species could 'enjoy' a little more slack on account of being near-human–Twi'leks, for example, weren't ideal, but the Empire could turn a blind eye to certain individuals if they served a beneficial purpose. Other species, though, faced the full wrath of the Empire, and the Wookiees in particular fell under the Imperial boot long ago for fighting as hard as they did against Emperor Palpatine's ascension. Most denizens of the Core worlds didn't know it, but the Empire kept a vise grip on the Wookiee homeworld of Kashyyyk, and even fewer realized that the Empire utilized the Wookiees' sizable strength, hardiness, and technical acumen for slave labor. Those big capital ships didn't build themselves.

Finally, the vessel shrunk down to a small speck in his view window, then disappeared into the hyperspace lane. The threat gone, Han finally let go of the breath he'd been holding on to. He shook himself free and forced a half-smile–best to get moving before anyone else showed up. His hands moved around the instrument panel to fire the engines back on. As the cockpit lit up in the faint orange glow of his myriad indicators, he hesitantly tinkered with the yoke. She swayed as he expected. *About time*, he fussed, then shot one more glance at where the Imperials had disappeared. Only then did he acknowledge that he knew, deep down in his gut, why they were here: because they could be.

Nar Shaddaa had perhaps never looked so good: that brown little dirtball didn't have a lot going for it, but at least it meant zero Imperial entanglements. Returning would mean having to face Chewie, though Han had been yelled at before, and the Wookiee wouldn't put a finger on him. Sure enough, as he came within radio contact distance, his ship's comm beeped with a hail.

He flicked the channel open nonchalantly. "Go ahead and gimme an earful," he droned.

"You're a difficult man to find sometimes," came a throaty

voice.

Han stiffened. Deino. *How in the hell did no one take that Corellia job?!* he cursed, then licked his lips before he answered. "What can I do you for?" he asked, feigning casual.

"The Hutts want to see you." As though she could read him plainly, she added, "Nothing bad. An opportunity. Come promptly," and without further explanation, the line closed.

"Fuck!" he bellowed as soon the call ended. Frustrated, he checked the calendar: three days. He'd been gone three fucking days. Jobs *never* sat on the board that long. What the hell was he going to say to them?! How to tell them no? How to tell them he couldn't?

He sat there for a moment in the silence of his cockpit, his thoughts flickering too quick to form into anything substantial. And then an odd sensation tickled at the back of his brain: maybe this was about–

No, it couldn't be, he insisted. He'd felt convinced for some time now that he was in the clear regarding his time with the Besadii on Ylesia. But maybe…maybe, finally, someone had connected the dots? Truth be told, he was less worried about the Desilijic and more concerned that his name had somehow stumbled into the ear slits of the Besadii, who might understandably still be a little sore over how Han left. They'd not sicced a bounty hunter on him for nothing. But if the Besadii knew, they'd not coordinate with the Desilijic to set a trap. Those two *kajidic* didn't collaborate, only compete. No, if the Desilijic were asking him in, it wasn't bait.

He cooled, exhaled as he leaned back. He'd think of something, he reassured himself. He had room. Latitude. Just had to figure out how to use it. His hands remembered themselves to find the yoke and semisconsciously engage the throttle.

Now, again, the question of the Wook. He frowned at the moon, toying with his options, then punched in a code to his radio. Hopefully, he'd get a response–she should have returned already.

"Solo," she crooned, her voice velvety despite the transmission noise. "You just won me a bet."

"Chewie isn't there, is he?"

Salla chuckled. "Hello to you, too. Yeah, he's here. I think he's still taking out his rage on a docking collar." She tsked him. "You're such a dick sometimes."

"Hey, I need my breathing room," he retorted, deciding as he said it that he'd skip the Spacebarn for now and land at the Palace hangar. Buy himself a little more time. Maybe even have something good to tell the Wook from the Hutts to cushion things.

"Is your breathing room going to turn into you showing up uninvited at my door later?"

"Why?" he queried distractedly, more concerned with maneuvering around a hauler that was sitting right in his lane.

"You know I don't like surprises."

He cleared his throat first. "I dunno. The Hutts have called me in; I gotta go there first."

"What'd you do?" she asked stiffly.

"I didn't do *anything*," he answered, a slight edge to his voice. "I just got to–listen, I'll let you know, okay? I'm getting closer, and I gotta call the tower."

She was silent for a few beats first. He could picture the frown she certainly was wearing. "Okay."

He still didn't have any idea how to squirm out from underneath the Hutts' importunity as he landed in the hangar, and the heartbeat in his ears almost drowned out any attempts at reason. He powered down, then robotically got up from his captain's chair. He didn't register closing up the ship, and the familiar corridor blurred around him. Once he passed the receiving room, however, and had to navigate through passages he rarely traveled, he finally took stock of the space. Coming to a halt, his head swiveling around as he tried to remember just how to get toward the front entrance of the expansive palatial grounds, an answer to his predicament came to him: his ship just wasn't quick enough, he'd say. It was true, at least. It wasn't really why.

Han transitioned from the back corridors of the Palace into

the more public spaces, guided there by the increasing brightness of the Great Hall. As he stepped into the space, he paused and arched his back, taking in the dome of colored glass and gold inlay that hovered high above him. The Hutt Palace, from a distance, didn't look like much. But here, in the twinkling beams and colored shafts of light of the Great Hall, visitors received a clear message: they were entering the belly of wealth and power.

The ostentation continued as he walked down a few wide, winding corridors of more extensive tilework before coming to the cavernous Audience Room. A lengthy, delicately woven carpet of fine tapestry paved the way across the polished black marble to the dias at the back. The room was rarely empty; the Hutts liked to keep an ever rotating entourage of special guests, artists, and musicians, who would line the mirrored walls and wait to be called forward for a performance or an interrogation.

Entering the massive doorway and giving the reticent guard a customary nod, Han eyeballed the space. At the back, Jiliac and Jabba the Hutts of *kajidic* Desilijic appeared rather comfortable sprawled out on their respective platforms. They each pinched their own mouthpiece to a shared hookah that sat between them, and the smoke gave the air a hazy and decently pleasant, spicy aroma. Hutts were sizable, slimy, amorphous creatures, more a blob of fat and flesh than anything resembling a figure, and the larger a Hutt got, the more difficult it became for them to independently propel themselves forward with the undulating of their giant and powerful tails. Han understood that Jabba and Jiliac were locomotive–Jabba, Jiliac's nephew, lead advisor, and presumed heir, definitely left Nar Shaddaa to go take care of business–but he'd never actually seen it himself, and the more times he visited, the more it seemed both were getting too large to do anything but eat, smoke, and bark orders.

Deino spotted him enter from across the room, and she made eyes for him to pick a spot and stay there. He quickly found a pocket beside a solitary robed Vurk and a gaggle of buzzing Rodians. After passing off some blunt instructions to the musicians performing near

the dias, Deino grabbed her skirts and crossed to him, her strong jaw set as always.

"It'll just be a minute while they wind the song down," she explained as she took a place beside him. "They don't like when the music gets cut off."

Han nodded his understanding; more time was always good. "No rush."

She scrutinized him, estimating something, then leaned in. "You're a sharp guy, but not as sharp as you think. I caught that *mistake* in the strongbox you handed over your last trip."

His mouth went dry to the accusation, but he'd already planned for this, so the charm oozed out of him. "I think you should start with your accounting manager."

Deino did not budge. "You think I didn't audit him already? Fortuna is many things I'm not very pleased about, but he's not dumb enough to pocket what's not his."

"Then maybe you need to check into your supplier on S-Two." He couldn't face her while he said it–someone like Deino didn't get a position like hers without being able to catch a tell–but he made it a point to swivel his head around to meet her gaze once the words were already in the air.

A hawk, he realized, as she narrowed eyes at him: that's what she'd always reminded him of. "What do you think is more likely, Captain Solo? That our distributor–that we've worked with for years across thousands of pilots–erred, or that a young pilot with a penchant for recklessness shortchanged us?"

He'd never felt quite so backed into a corner in so large a room. "What's your price?"

She stared at him, mouth flat and indifferent. "I want for nothing in here. But believe me, I'll remember it." Her gaze flickered to the front of the Audience Room. "Go."

Han strolled up and found his usual stopping point before the Hutts and bowed. Jiliac, the larger and senior Hutt, dropped the hookah and narrowed bulbous eyes at him. *Drugged*, the pilot

recognized. That could play to his favor.

"Successfully returned to Nar Shaddaa, Captain Solo?" Jiliac asked in languid Huttese.

He bowed again and answered in Basic. "Correct, Your Excellency."

"We're glad to see you," the Hutt continued, pausing again to take another pull. "We have a special assignment that we've been waiting to offer you upon your return."

Han stiffened but held his breath in an attempt to stay calm. Losing his cool now and in front of everyone wouldn't do him any good. He needed to stay on top of this conversation. "I figured you'd ask me. And honestly, I'm very, very flattered you'd want me to do the job."

Jiliac reared back a little, gawking first at Deino before estimating Han again. "News has already reached you about this? How?"

There was a smidge of irritation in Jiliac's tone, and Han swallowed hard before he answered. "I saw it. I saw you all had a hard time getting it assigned to anyone, and I know Mako won't take it–"

"We were never going to ask Mako," Jiliac interrupted, curt.

"Maybe let His Excellency finish," Deino suggested tightly, to which Han planted his feet and clasped his hands behind his back, ready to listen.

Jiliac took another pull on the hookah before he spoke again. "Our Promenade has seen better days. The handful of casinos we own do not perform as well as we'd like, and the area, overall, is suffering lower numbers of tourists. I've decided to make an investment in the entertainment sector of our moon in an effort to get numbers back up. We are opening a showcase venue."

Han's eyes narrowed in skepticism. "Showcase venue? Don't you own all the clubs in the Promenade?" *And the Red Light District?* In fact, he wondered, was there anything in the entertainment sector that the Hutts *didn't* own?

"We do, but they're not doing well, either. We've decided to go in a slightly different direction."

Han nodded as he processed, a tightness still lingering in his chest. "And what exactly does this have to do with me?"

Another inhale and slow exhale of smoke. "I have a dancer here. Incredibly talented, very bright, very headstrong. She has convinced me to let her open up a theater. She's a human, about your height, attractive features. Maybe you've seen her before?"

Han shook his head. Entertainers came and went through the Audience Room, but their performances were not for people like him. Additionally, the Desilijic Hutts often kept a harem of humanoid females, though Han had never paid much attention. Even if he did, the turnover rate was so high that he likely met a new one every time he visited. Just out of curiosity, Han glanced at the woman currently chained to Jabba's side. She was a Twi'lek, with skin of a pale yellow-green that made it hard to distinguish her from the Hutt. She lay beside him, barely dressed and with glassy eyes; clearly, she'd been intoxicated with something. Han had never seen her before, and he'd probably never see her again.

Jiliac was unfazed by Han's distant response. "No matter; you'll meet her in due time. She is straining Nar Shaddaa's stock of performers suitable to her needs. She's brought it to our attention that there is not enough skill in our vicinity." Jiliac's gaze centered on Han. "We need you to take her off-world to find talent elsewhere."

Han wasn't sure if the sudden clench in his jaw could be read by a Hutt, but he had no doubts Deino caught it, and he shuffled on his feet to distract. He and Chewie had already fought about this before coming here. From the latter's perspective, to make profit for the Hutts, who were slavers, was unforgivable. From the former's, they didn't have much choice. In the Mid and Outer Rim, honest work was hard to come by. Whether Hutt or not, they'd rub shoulders with people with dirty hands. So instead, they'd struck a deal: they could move drugs and goods, but no people. Never people. It was the only promise he'd made to the Wook.

It took him a few tries, but he managed to lift his eyes back up to Jiliac. "I can't do that. I told you when I started: I don't smuggle sentients."

Jiliac didn't flinch, like he'd anticipated the objection. "Smuggling will not be necessary, Captain Solo. You are doing nothing illegal, and neither is she. For precautionary measures, regardless, we have a new transponder code for your ship and the appropriate IDs, just in case anyone asks any questions."

Though trying to stay respectful, his eyes still narrowed. "Why the concern about anybody asking questions?"

Jiliac coolly sucked again on the hookah. "We typically like to keep our business to ourselves, Captain Solo. You're well aware of that."

That had to be a stock answer. Han glanced down again at the pitiful Twilek; as Jabba reached for a *chuba* from a bowl offered by a supplicating servant, she merely let herself be pulled by the tautness of the chain wrapped at her throat, then her whole chest sagged again once the slack returned.

He gestured at her. "So she's not a–"

"No, no, Captain Solo," Jabba interjected, then engulfed the still chittering *chupa* in a single bite. He struggled then to continue his answer as the creature squirmed and fought for freedom from the gaping maw. "She's special," the Hutt finally managed. "And you, too–this was a task we did not want to trust with just anyone. You've been impressing us. You're diligent, timely, stay out of mess–all qualities we enjoy in a pilot. We need special tasks like this fairly often. It would be reassuring to have you on our roster."

Han straightened up. "I'm certainly interested in promotion."

"We know you are," Jabba continued. "We like to reward quality. Reliability. Expertise. And the pay on the job reflects that, as well."

Han waited for Jabba to say more, then his gaze darted between the two Hutts before he realized it was his turn. "What's the rate?"

"Two thousand," Jiliac answered without hesitation.

"Two thousand…*credits*?" Han asked, his voice straining over the currency.

"Of course," Jabba answered, reaching for another prey. "We recall that you take nothing else."

Han's breath had caught in his throat, and he had to force a cough to get an exhale out. Two thousand. He'd never been paid that much. And that this might beget additional work–*easy* work, too, it sounded like–might be too good to pass up.

"I thought you would find that satisfactory," Jiliac continued, humored, then emphatically gestured at Deino. She stepped up with hand extended, her palms full.

Han received the objects she bore, then glanced down at them. Of course, the transponder code for the 'Suub and two sets of alias IDs. He gawked at them for a beat: it seemed they didn't expect him to decline.

"Uh, I'll need a few days to get things together on the *Starmite*. To get this stuff loaded," he said, as he lifted the transponder code up. "I hope that's okay."

"As we expected," Jiliac responded, then the Hutt rocked back and forth in pleasure.

"Well, I'm glad to be of service," Han offered, then let go of another huff. He was quiet a moment, proud, still shocked, then remembered one last detail. "Uh, where to?"

Jiliac had puffed again on the hookah and took his time to enjoy the pull. As the smoke lazily left his mouth, his languid eyes lifted. "Are you familiar with Esseles?"

The aliases nearly dropped from Han's hands as his whole body went rigid. Esseles. The blockade at Brentaal IV. The Core.

His jaw seized and a ringing started in his ears. "Esseles?" he repeated, incredulous.

"Correct," Jiliac returned, either ignorant or nonchalant to the tightness in Han's voice. "We've made arrangements in Calamar. Are you familiar?"

The question surely was a taunt. They *knew* he knew. In fact, for how everything had gone so far in this negotiation, he'd not be surprised if they pulled up the holostills from all his trophy tournaments in and around the Darpa Sector.

Somewhere, deep in his chest, the feeling came first and, all muffled and struggling, made its way up into his head, reverberating ever clearer until his consciousness finally identified the thought: No. *No*. No! And, with each breath, the louder his internal unwillingness became, the stronger his conviction: Absolutely not. Out of the question. He might as well deliver himself on a silver platter to the local moff.

In any other situation, he would have tossed the aliases down and boldly declared his refusal, and in certain company, he would have a couple choice words for whoever the fuck imagined they were going to swindle him into this kind of outrageous idea. But the Hutts…they'd have his head for talking to them like that. Still, he needed to decline. He needed to think of something.

"Sorry," he started, handing the aliases back in the direction of Deino. "I can't agree to that."

Jiliac paused in his reverie, then sternly stared him down. "Why not?"

Han's gaze darted to Jabba to see if the younger Hutt might intervene on his behalf. Alas, Jabba seemed conveniently busy with the Twilek slave; even he was aware of his uncle's pertinacity. *Damn them*, Han resigned: he might have to tell them the truth after all, or at least something like it. "I have a little too much experience with Imps."

"Exactly; that's why I'm asking you, " Jiliac countered. "You've been through their systems, crisscrossed their worlds. You can dress like them, talk like them. You will not bring any undue attention to yourself, and we spent a great deal of money on those documents," Jiliac gestured at Han's hand, "to help ensure that nothing unpleasant would find you."

Han couldn't help but cough out a choke of surprise at Jiliac's

answer. The Hutts always knew more than they let on, but he didn't think they knew about *that*. He'd been pretty tight-lipped about his life before coming to the Outer Rim. Someone must have run their mouth, and scowling in aggravation, he guessed who: Mako never could resist telling a captivating story, even if it wasn't his to tell.

He scrambled for a different excuse. "And if something does come up on scanners? I'm not exactly on the Empire's good side. I don't know what will happen if I head back there." Hyperbole, but not entirely a lie.

This answer gave Jiliac pause, and Han could see the Hutt turning the notion around in the mucous-laden rolls of his head. The longer it went on, the more sure Han was that Jiliac might actually accede to the loss, though it might mean Han took a hit on his employment. *So be it*, he accepted.

"We'll pay you four thousand," came the answer, not from Jiliac, but from Jabba, whose insistence seemed to surprise even the senior Hutt. And then, at seeing Han's mouth open and close like a fresh-caught fish, Jabba added, "Additionally, as reward for your loyalty, upon a successful and safe return, we would be glad to offer you a thirteen percent cut on all future smuggling endeavors." Jabba graciously gestured down at the Corellian. "After all, you have been in our steady employ for well over six months now. You have been due a raise."

Han managed somehow to close his mouth. His tongue felt dry and thick, his cognition muddy. Even the conviction to refuse that had earlier erupted from his gut had dissolved somewhere.

Detached, Han slowly nodded, heard but did not comprehend the muted directions from Jiliac and the closing remarks of Deino. Distracted, he saw his feet start to turn to exit, but somehow he remembered himself and gave the customary bow. Numb, he walked silent and stiff the whole way out of the Audience Room, down the passages, out the door, and even onto the open square.

Only when he stepped into the discord of the surrounding commercial district did he finally catch up with himself. He ran a

hand through his hair, feeling the sweat at his pits and the shallowness of his breath. He exhaled, closing his eyes, trying to replay what seemed so clouded. What in all the skies had just happened? What had he agreed to?

Despite himself, he reconsidered. Was it really that bad an idea? Hadn't he done worse things? *Stupider* things? And more, what was the alternative, really? Scrape by even longer, get lost in the endless cycle of breakdowns and emergency fixes? What happened when the ship finally caved, and he had nothing to show for more than a year of toil and expense? He had wanted a break. This was it.

With each breath, he sank more into himself. His weight settled onto the hard permacrete under his boots. He wiped at his nose, sniffled, started to take stock of the buzzing of people around him, the noise, the stink of the whole moon. He needed to tell Chewie, he faintly realized. The Wookiee would have to come with–he couldn't handle the 'Suub alone for that long of a trip, not in general and definitely not if anything happened.

It took more focus than he'd expect to find Chewie's contact information. As the call rang, he let go of a rattled breath, unsure of what the Wookiee would be more upset about: the destination or the cargo. He thought, too, that he'd find out just how seriously Chewie took the life debt.

The call picked up and Han was met with a flurry of yelling so loud and so furious that none of it registered to him. He let Chewie rag on, the Wook screaming and threatening over Han's disappearance, before he finally cut in. "Yeah, I know," he started, "Just–hey listen, I have something I gotta tell you."

Chewie went quiet, clearly able to pick up the unease in Han's tone. [*What is it*?]

His throat closed, and he forced out a small cough before he could answer. "Uh, I got a job."